

1963

JANUARY 2

Viet Cong ambush South Vietnamese (ARVN) infantry and their American advisers at Ap Bac. It is the first major Viet Cong victory over American-supported troops.

MAY 8

South Vietnamese forces shoot nine unarmed Buddhist demonstrators in Hue, leading to widespread anti-Diem protests by Buddhists. South Vietnam is thrown into political crisis.

JUNE 11

In protest at Diem's policies, Buddhist monk Thich Quang Duc burns himself to death in central Saigon. International opinion of the Diem regime plummets.

NOVEMBER 2

President Diem is assassinated in the course of a military coup approved by the United States. General Duong Van Minh takes power at the head of a military junta.